Sri Lanka Tea Plantations

Poverty and Women’s Rights

Origin of Tea in Sri Lanka

1824: British smuggled tea from China to Ceylon, but not to sell; they continued to make profits off of coffee plants that grew well in the area

1839: Tea plants from Assam and Calcutta were brought to Sri Lanka for experimentation as well

1867: British native James Taylor began the tea industry in Ceylon, since coffee crops were destroyed by a fungus; the English East India had a monopoly over the tea industry when it began

1880s: Tea processing technology was developed quickly

1965: Sri Lanka became world's largest tea exporter

Currently, Sri Lanka is the 3rd largest tea exporter in the world

Tea Production

Humidity, cool temperatures, and rainfall in Sri Lanka make ideal conditions for tea production

Ceylon Black Tea, Ceylon Green Tea, and Ceylon White Tea are the three main types of tea grown in Sri Lanka

Tea production regions include the Central Province, Uva Province, Southern Province, and the Sabaragamuwa Province

The steps of tea processing includes plucking, withering, rolling, fermentation/oxidation, firing/drying, sorting & grading, and tasting and assessing

Tea Plantation Conditions

Grueling work hours with not enough pay leading to poverty; workers currently get paid approximately 750 Rupees ($9.91) a day

Small living quarters

Lack of education, nutrition, and proper health care

Women are underpaid for the amount of work they do, and then they attend their “second shift” working at home (15 - 17 hours of work a day)

Women are are excluded from decision making processes, so they cannot assume positions of power

Women Workers

Women must attend to house chores and other gender normative duties, so they give up their education - the literacy rate for women age 15-24 is 74.7% while it is 88.3% for men; only 6.7% of girls age 15-19 go to school

There are higher maternal mortality and infant mortality rates for women working on plantations

Women also lack health and reproductive rights

Violence against women on plantations, including sexual harassment, is common

Effects of COVID-19

Work on tea plantations are permitted in anywhere in Sri Lanka, although strict lockdown/quarantine rules are enforced everywhere else

Little to no sanitary access (soap and water and even masks are not always available)

No health education or public health measures on tea plantations

Tight, small living conditions do not allow for social distancing; furthermore, early curfew is forcing all workers to come back to cramped quarters, exasperating the already crowded situation

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